

## American Self-Storage Facilities outnumber McDonald's

By: Chaz Wilke - Staff Writer



As spring rolls into full effect, that dreaded yearly spring cleaning lingers around the middle of most Americans' to-do list. It's a responsibility that always feels better once completed, but may linger as a sizeable burden beforehand.

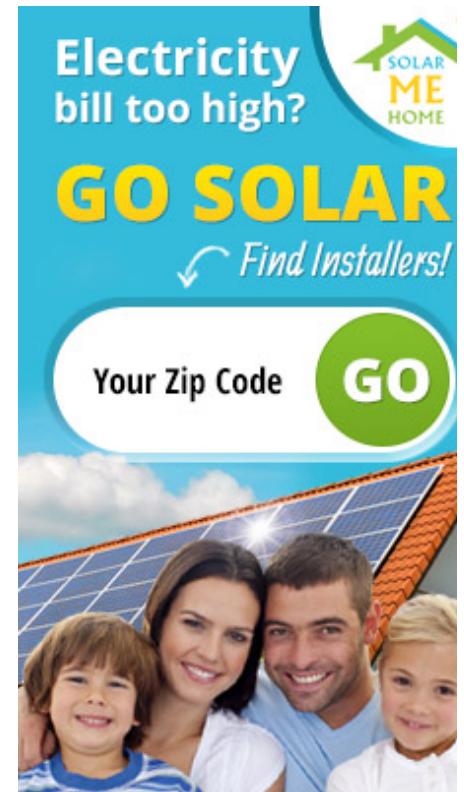
An increasing number of Americans continue to seek additional storage space to trick themselves into thinking they've cleaned up. But really people are just sweeping that clutter under the rug. It's just that rug is now a storage facility across town.

### Out of sight, out of mind

This may seem ideal for those trinkets and memories you may not feel prepared to part with. A storage unit offers secure refuge for your stuff in a well-lit, easy to access environment. It also becomes easy to forget. As depicted on reality TV shows like Storage Wars. Bidders fight over forgotten storage units, hoping to discover abandoned treasure buried deep within mountains of junk.

And perhaps that's the problem. Most people amass physical representations of meaningful memories as they journey through life. Scrapbooking teeters between hobby and addiction for plenty. Baby clothes, old report cards, trinkets and baubles can all have nostalgic and meaningful value to those who own them.

No one is taking away the importance of remembering the good times, but if you find yourself boxing up these memories and lugging them by the carload to a storage facility, consider each of those things you choose to keep.



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Recent figures show that Americans by and large are renting out more storage units than ever before. In fact, with 48,500 locations (<http://bit.ly/1DlioDI>) across America, the self-storage industry has three times the footprint of McDonald's. For perspective on that number, "There is about 7 square feet of self-storage space nationally for each person (<http://bit.ly/1DI3DLw>) in the United States," says Maruice Pogoda, president of a company that specializes in management of self-storage facilities.



### Can there really be that many things worth saving offsite?

The answer is subjective and nebulous. Everybody has that thing they just can't live without. The problem with that is if that object is locked away in a storage facility across town, you're already living without it. And the industry has merely grown to meet demand, to the point where Pogoda states, "This sector isn't under the radar any longer. It is very much a big business."

Some seek storage units for short term refuge for items too big for an apartment, or in preparation of moving to a larger home. Many, however, see self-storage units as a permanent addition to their storage space. This forces the renter of the storage unit pay an additional monthly sum for keepsakes, treasures and junk that is locked away, far out of sight and out of mind.

The minimalist living site [mnmlist.com](http://mnmlist.com) offers a comprehensive guide to letting go of possessions for those clinging to items stored in boxes buried upon other boxes in a storage unit located perhaps miles away from home.

The first thing to note is how difficult it is to let go. "Letting go can be an amazing release, and when you do, you'll feel liberated and light. But allowing yourself to let go is an emotional thing (<http://bit.ly/1GqolU4>), and as with anything emotional, it's not always simple," [mnmlist](http://mnmlist.com) notes.

[Mnmlist.com](http://mnmlist.com) gives two important points for the average self-storage unit owner:

#### Focus on the present.

Remember the here and now, and understand the additional cost saving trinkets from the past costs you in the present moment. No one is saying to destroy your memories of great past occurrences, but understand the present burden of storing physical representations of that memory.

#### 2. Focus on quality over quantity.

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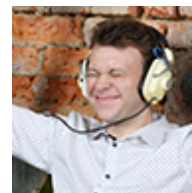
## Takeaway

There is subjectivity to de-cluttering. No one should force you to throw out or donate valuable items or memorable trinkets. But, if you find yourself paying a monthly fee to store items that you rarely if ever actually see, you may need to ask yourself a hard question. Is storing these memories worth the monthly cost?



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